

REVOLTS BEFORE 1857

The Wider Story Behind the Great Revolt

Land Revenue Systems · Sanyasi, Paika, Ahom, Pagalpanthi, Kol, Munda, Santhal & Indigo Uprisings
(1764–1900)

- Headings & Definitions ● Explanations ● Highlighter = Key Facts 🎯 Exam Tip ✗ Common Mistake
🧠 Memory Trick

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LAND REVENUE SYSTEMS — THE ROOT OF DISCONTENT

In the name of "reform," the British began taxing land itself — **land revenue**: a share of whatever a farmer grew had to be paid to the Company. The British devised three separate systems to collect this revenue: the **Permanent Settlement**, the **Ryotwari** system, and the **Mahalwari** system.

1 Permanent Settlement (Zamindari System)

Introduced by Cornwallis in 1793, in the Bengal, Bihar & Orissa region. Zamindars (landowners) were appointed as intermediaries between the farmer and the British — the British avoided approaching farmers directly, hoping to keep "goodwill," while the zamindar did the actual, often harsh, collecting.

- In return, zamindars received hereditary rights over the land — the right to collect revenue passed from father to son, generation after generation.
- If a zamindar failed to deposit the fixed revenue by the set time, his landholding rights were taken away — this is the famous **Sunset Clause** ("Sunset Law").
- That is why this system is also called the **Zamindari System** / the "landholding system."

- It is called **PERMANENT** because the revenue amount, once fixed, was never revised again — contrast this with Ryotwari, where revenue was revised every 30 years.



Did You Know?

This hereditary right to collect revenue (passed father to son) is the same pattern behind hereditary landowning castes still found today — like the Deshmukhs & Fadnavis of Maharashtra!

2 Ryotwari System



Introduced by Munro and Read in 1820, in South India — mainly the Madras region (today's Tamil Nadu) and parts of Maharashtra. Based on the Ricardian Theory of Rent.

- "Ryot" simply means peasant / farmer.
- Unlike the Zamindari system, there was no middleman here — the British collected tax directly from the Ryot.
- Revenue here was revised every 30 years, not fixed permanently.

3 Mahalwari System

Introduced in 1822 by Holt Mackenzie (who took it to the Bengal region) and William Bentinck (who extended it to Punjab).

- "Mahal" means a group of villages.
- Revenue was collected from the village headman — not the zamindar, not the individual farmer.
- Crucially, the headman was chosen by the villagers themselves, not appointed by the British.

✗ Common Mistake

Don't confuse who actually collects the revenue! Permanent Settlement → Zamindar collects (indirect). Ryotwari → British collect directly from the Ryot. Mahalwari → the village headman collects (chosen by villagers, not the British).

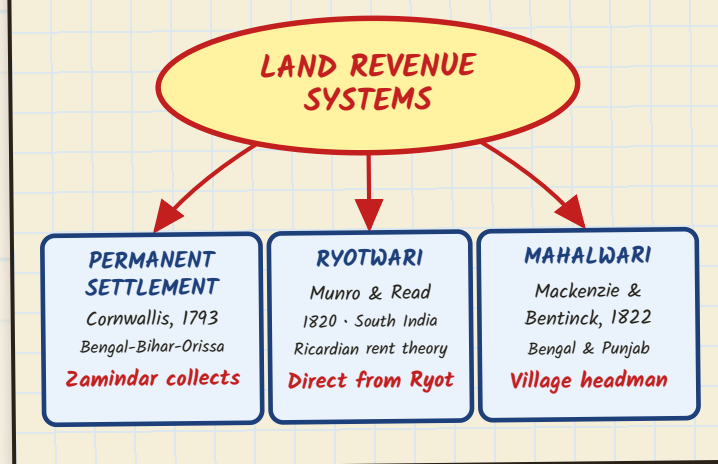
System	Introduced By	Year	Region
Permanent Settlement	Cornwallis	1793	Bengal, Bihar & Orissa

Ryotwari	Munro & Read	1820	South India (Madras; parts of Maharashtra)
Mahalwari	Holt Mackenzie & William Bentinck	1822	Bengal & Punjab

🎯 Exam Tip

The exam-favourite triad for all three systems is **Who? When? Where?** — learn the table above by row, not just by name!

🧠 Fig 1: Three Ways to Collect Land Revenue

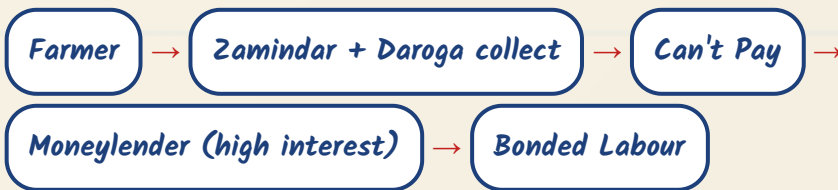


Why Did This Create So Much Anger?

Most of the areas under the Zamindari system were exactly the **Bengal-Bihar-Orissa belt** (today's Bengal, Bihar, Jharkhand & Bangladesh) — which is why the largest number of these early uprisings broke out right here.

- Cornwallis also introduced the **police inspector (daroga) system**, so a police daroga would accompany the zamindar to enforce collection.
- If the harvest was poor, farmers had to borrow from **moneylenders** — often the zamindars themselves, wearing a second hat.
- Interest rates were so high that farmers could never repay even the interest, let alone the principal.
- Inability to repay pushed many into **bonded labour**.
- This deep resentment against zamindars and the British — among both farmers and tribal communities — fed directly into the wave of revolts covered on the next five pages.

Why Villagers Still Fear the Daroga (tap to expand) ▼



Understand it like this...

A farmer with a bad harvest tells the zamindar, "I don't have the money." So he borrows from a moneylender instead — often the *same* zamindar wearing a different hat! The interest is so high he can never repay even the interest, let alone the principal → bonded labour.



Memory Trick

The system's own name tells you who pays! **Ryotwari** → the Ryot (peasant) pays directly. **Mahalwari** → the Mahal (village group) pays via its headman. **Zamindari** → the Zamindar is the middleman who actually hands over the money.

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SANYASI-FAKIR REBELLION + THE PAIKA REBELLION

The Sanyasi-Fakir Rebellion

After the **Battle of Buxar (1764)**, where the British defeated **Shah Alam II**, **Shuja-ud-Daula** & **Mir Qasim**, the Company took firm control of Bengal — and with it, the Mughal and Awadh courts.

- Wandering **Sanyasis** (Hindu ascetics) and **Fakirs** (Muslim ascetics) had long travelled on pilgrimage with their expenses borne by the local kingdom/court — a form of royal patronage.
- The British refused to continue this patronage, and instead declared them "bandits."
- Angered, they revolted, growing through the **1770s**.

- Leaders: **Manju Shah, Bhawani Pathak, and Devi Chaudhurani** (a notable female participant/leader).
- Region: **Bengal**.

Both events are dramatised in novels by **Bankim Chandra Chatterjee**: *Anandmath* and *Devi Chaudhurani*.



The Paika Rebellion



Year: **1817**. Region: **Khurda, Odisha**. Leader: **Bakshi Jagabandhu Vidyadhar**, military commander of the Khurda Kingdom.

- The Odisha (Gajapati) rulers of Khurda had come under British control by accepting the **Subsidiary Alliance**.
- Subsidiary Alliance: introduced by **Wellesley** in **1798**; its terms required the kingdom to **disband its own local army** and accept British troops instead — at the kingdom's expense.
- The **Nizam of Hyderabad** was the first ruler to accept the Subsidiary Alliance (1798).
- When Khurda's local *paik* soldiers were disbanded and replaced, **Bakshi Jagabandhu** led them in revolt (1817).
- In recent years, the Odisha government has sought to have the Paika Rebellion officially recognised as the "First War of Independence," but the Central Government has not accepted this, arguing the revolt was fought to restore the Khurda kingdom rather than for a united national independence.

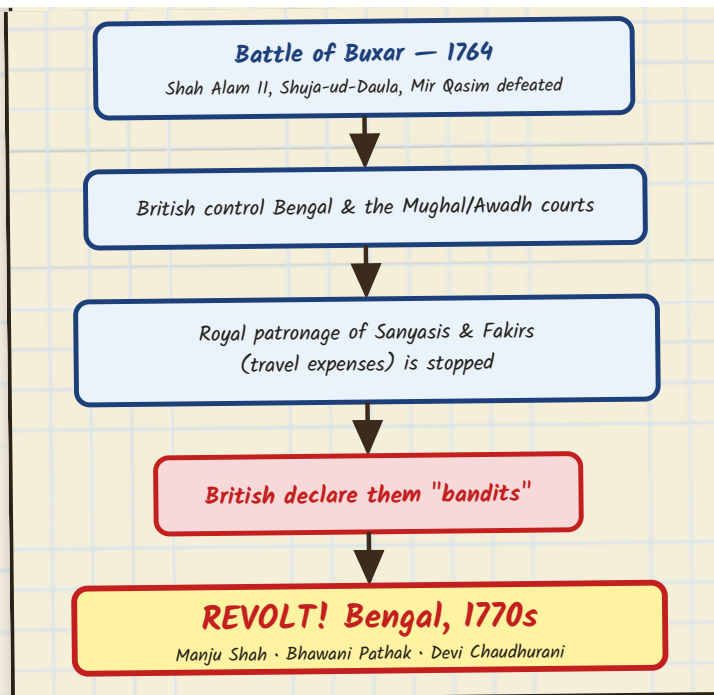


The Carnatic Wars – Dupleix, Coote & Wandiwash (tap to expand) ▼

Revolt	Leader(s)	Year	Region
Sanyasi-Fakir Rebellion	Manju Shah, Bhawani Pathak, Devi Chaudhurani	1770s	Bengal
Paika Rebellion	Bakshi Jagabandhu Vidyadhar	1817	Khurda, Odisha



Fig 2: From Buxar to "Bandits"



✗ Common Mistake

Subsidiary Alliance (1798, Wellesley) is *not* the same as annexation — the kingdom kept its throne, just lost its own army and foreign policy control. It was specifically the **disbanding of Khurda's own soldiers** under this Alliance that sparked the Paika Rebellion.

🎯 Exam Tip

Two "novel connections" to remember: **Anandmath & Devi Chaudhurani** (both by Bankim Chandra Chatterjee) → **Sanyasi-Fakir Rebellion**. Don't mix this up with **Neel Darpan** (Page 6), which covers the Indigo Revolt!

🧠 Memory Trick

The Nizam of Hyderabad was **FIRST** to accept the Subsidiary Alliance (1798) — and Khurda's own paiks lost their livelihood under that very same policy, sparking Bakshi Jagabandhu's revolt two decades later (1817)!



THE AHOM REVOLT + THE PAGALPANTHI

The Ahom Revolt (Assam)

Led by Gomdhar Konwar in 1828. This followed the First Anglo-Burmese War (1824–1826), which ended with the Treaty of Yandaboo (1826).

- Before the treaty, the Ahom Kingdom (Assam, and part of today's Bangladesh) was under the influence of the Burmese (Myanmar) empire.
- Under the Treaty of Yandaboo, this region came under British control, and the British promised they would withdraw.
- They did not leave — two years passed with no withdrawal.
- Gomdhar Konwar led a revolt against this broken promise in 1828.
- The Company suppressed the revolt, but — having made an impression — chose not to hold the territory outright: they returned the territory to the Ahoms and withdrew.

The Pagalpanthi (Bengal)

A movement started around 1825 by Karam Shah and his son Tipu Shah, in the Bengal region.

- Tipu Shah established a distinct sect — a bit like how Akbar had once established Din-i-Ilahi: a new set of beliefs not fitting neatly into existing Hindu or Muslim orthodoxy.
- Karam Shah appealed to both Hindus and Muslims, urging orthodox believers to drop certain rigid practices and pointing out flaws on both sides.
- People mockingly called them "mad" ("Pagal") — hence Pagalpanthi.
- It is studied here because the movement gradually turned into a revolt against local landlords.

 Battle of Saraighat, 1671 (tap to expand) ▼

Revolt	Leader	Year	Region
Ahom Revolt	Gomdhar Konwar	1828	Assam
Pagalpanthi	Karam Shah & Tipu Shah	1825	Bengal

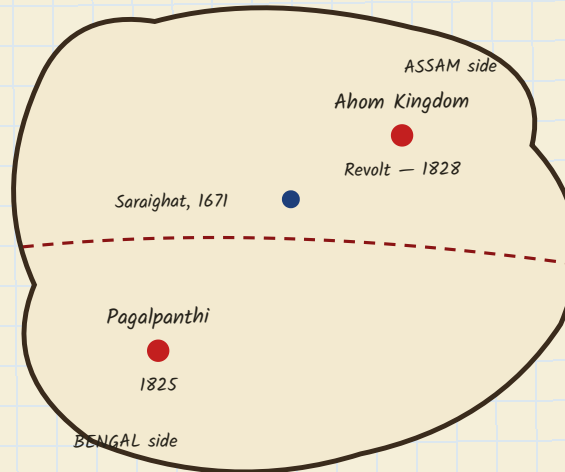
1671 Saraighat (Ahoms win)

1824-26 Anglo-Burmese War

1826 Treaty of Yandaboo

1828 Gomdhar Konwar's revolt

Fig 3: Two Frontiers of Resistance



✗ Common Mistake

Don't confuse the **Ahom Revolt** (1828, against the British, led by Gomdhar Konwar) with the **Battle of Saraighat** (1671, against the Mughals, led by Lachit Borphukan) — the same Ahom Kingdom defending itself, but against two completely different invaders, 150+ years apart!

🎯 Exam Tip

The Treaty of Yandaboo (1826) ended the First Anglo-Burmese War and gave the British control of Assam — but they didn't withdraw as promised, which is exactly what sparked Gomdhar Konwar's revolt (1828).

📌 Small But Mighty

Assam's Ahom Kingdom fought off two very different powers within 157 years — the Mughals (1671, Ahoms won) and the British (1828, revolt suppressed, but the land was later returned)!

KOL MUTINY + THE MUNDA REBELLION (ULGULAN)

The Kol Mutiny

Led by **Buddhu Bhagat** in **1831**. A tribal uprising in the **Chota Nagpur Plateau** region, involving the **Ho** and **Munda** tribes.

The Munda Rebellion – "Ulgulan"

The British wanted revenue, and this forest-rich plateau (though its mineral wealth wasn't the British focus at the time — agriculture was) was a target. They wanted to clear tribal forest land for cultivation, so agricultural tax could be earned.

- Led by **Birsa Munda**, who led the **Ho and Munda** tribes' uprising.
- Born **15 November 1875**; began leading the movement around the age of 20, i.e. c. **1895**.
- His birthday, 15 November, is now observed as **Tribal Pride Day**.
- Directed against the "**Diku**" — outsiders, specifically outsider landlords who arrived once agriculture (and zamindari-style revenue collection) came to tribal land.
- The Munda community upheld the Khuntkatti system — collective/joint land ownership, with no single owner: the community would grow, eat and live together with a strong communal bond. The movement also carried a religious dimension, resisting outside religious influence.
- Also called the **Ulgulan** ("uprising") — commonly explained as a call to overthrow oppressive rule. Many tribal groups still invoke the word today.
- The uprising began around 1895; Birsa Munda was captured in 1899 and died in jail in **1900** — this account attributes his death to slow poisoning by the British.

 "**Ulgulan!**" — the Munda rallying cry, meaning roughly "rise up, overthrow the oppressor" — still invoked by tribal groups today.

1875

Birsa Munda is born (15 November).

~1895

At around age 20, he begins leading the movement against the Diku and the British.

1899

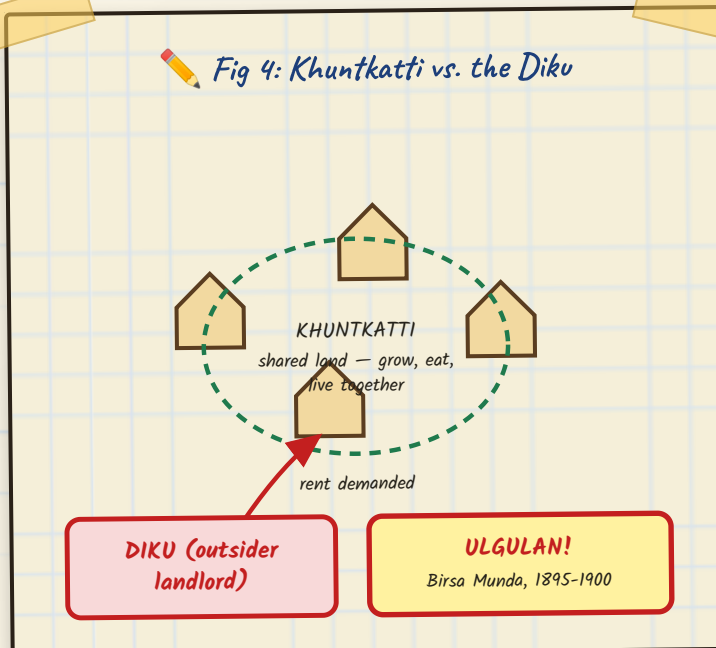
The Ulgulan is declared; Birsa Munda is captured.

1900

He dies in jail — this account describes it as slow poisoning by the British.

Revolt	Leader	Year	Tribes Involved
Kol Mutiny	Buddhu Bhagat	1831	Ho & Munda
Munda Rebellion (Ulgulan)	Birsa Munda	1895-1900	Munda & Ho

Fig 4: Khuntkatti vs. the Diku



✗ Common Mistake

Modern **Naxalism** is *not* a continuation of the Kol Mutiny or the Munda Rebellion! Despite the geographic overlap, Naxalism began later and separately, taking its name from **Naxalbari village, West Bengal** — don't link the two in an answer.

🧠 Memory Trick

Remember Birsa Munda by three 15-Novembers: **BORN** 15 Nov 1875 → the date is now **Tribal Pride Day** → and **Jharkhand** itself was carved out of Bihar on 15 November, 2000!

A



THE SANTHAL REBELLION + THE MOPLAH REBELLION

The Santhal Rebellion

Studied here among the Tribal Uprisings, though it falls chronologically right before 1857 itself — began in **1855**, led by **Sidhu and Kanhu Murmu** (two of four Murmu brothers; the other two aren't essential for exams).

- The **Santhal** tribe is India's third-largest tribal group, after the **Bhil** and **Gond** tribes.
- India's current President, **Droupadi Murmu** — the country's first tribal President — belongs to this tribe.
- Around **1832**, the British demarcated a forest tract of the Chota Nagpur Plateau called **Damin-i-Koh** for cultivation, and brought in the Santhal tribe (believed to trace its origins to the Cambodia/Southeast Asia region) to clear this forest and farm it.
- Once settled, a zamindar was placed over the Santhals, collecting tax and rent — and the same trap of moneylenders and high interest followed, just as on Page 1.
- The Santhals fought hard, but had only bows and arrows against British artillery — they could not win militarily.
- The British ultimately overpowered them; local kings and officials also sided with the British.

Why the Rebellion Ultimately Failed (tap to expand) ▼

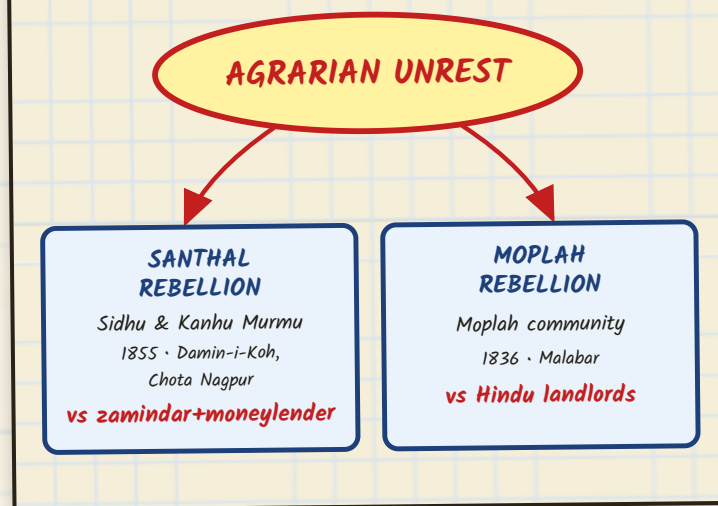
The Moplah Rebellion

Year: **1836** (a separate, much larger Moplah uprising also occurred in 1921, studied separately). Region: **Malabar**.

- The **Moplah** (Mappila) are a Muslim community of the Malabar region.
- In 1836, they revolted against **Hindu landlords**.

Revolt	Leader(s)	Year	Region
Santhal Rebellion	Sidhu & Kanhu Murmu	1855	Damin-i-Koh, Chota Nagpur
Moplah Rebellion	Moplah community	1836	Malabar

 Fig 5: Two Uprisings, One Pattern



Common Mistake

The Santhals were *not* native to the Damin-i-Koh/Chota Nagpur area — the British brought them in (from a region believed to trace back toward Cambodia) around 1832 specifically to clear the forest for farming.

Exam Tip

Santhal Rebellion (1855) is grouped under Tribal Uprisings even though it falls just two years before 1857 — sort your revision by **theme** (tribal / peasant / religious), not only by strict date order.



Memory Trick

Bhil → Gond → Santhal: that's India's top-3 tribal-population order. And Santhal is the tribe of India's first tribal President, Droupadi Murmu!

THE INDIGO REVOLT + THE ROAD TO 1857

Indigo ("neel") is a plant that yields a natural blue dye — no longer common today since synthetic dyes replaced it. The plant demands far more water than rice, and gradually makes the soil unfertile. The British wanted it anyway, to sell at a good rate in the European market.

□ The "Advance Payment" Trap

- Farmers preferred growing wheat and rice for their own food — indigo brought no food and ruined the soil.
- So the British devised a system: sign an agreement, and **pay the farmer in advance**, before the crop was even planted.
- Drawn in by the immediate money, cultivators signed without reading or understanding the contract's terms — this was a trap: it bound them to keep growing indigo.
- With no way out, the planters revolted in **1859**.

📖 How the "Advance Payment" Trap Worked (tap to expand) ▼

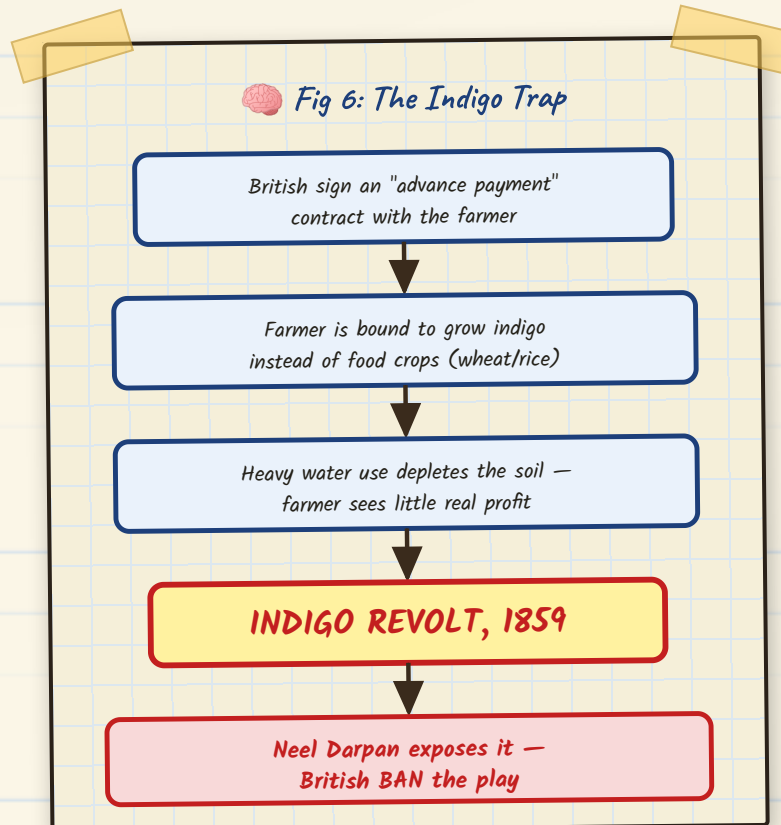
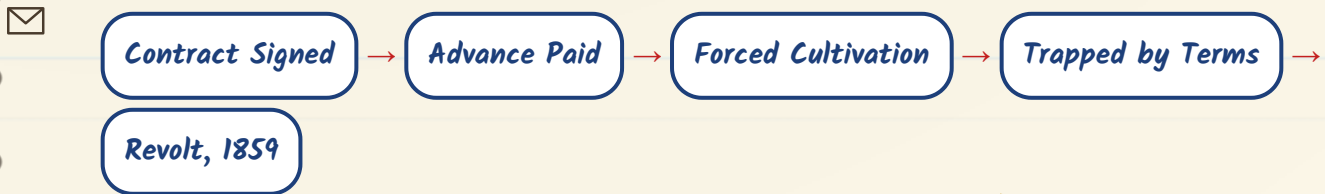
👊 The Revolt & Its Voice

Leaders: Digambar Biswas and Bishnu Biswas. The revolt was dramatised in the play **Neel Darpan** ("Blue/Indigo Mirror") by Dinabandhu Mitra — its impact was so great that the British banned the play.

✗ Common Mistake

Don't attribute *Neel Darpan* to Bankim Chandra Chatterjee! Bankim Chandra wrote *Anandmath* & *Devi Chaudhurani* (Sanyasi-Fakir Rebellion, Page 2). *Neel Darpan* (Indigo Revolt) was written by Dinabandhu Mitra.

Revolt	Leader(s)	Year	Region
Indigo Revolt	Digambar Biswas & Bishnu Biswas	1859	Bengal



📌 Fun Fact

Indigo's Bengali name gives *Neel Darpan* ("Blue/Indigo Mirror") its title — the "mirror" held up to expose the cruelty of forced cultivation.



Putting It All Together — A Century of Unrest



1764

Battle of Buxar — the backdrop that eventually leads to the Sanyasi-Fakir Rebellion.



1770s

Sanyasi-Fakir Rebellion — Bengal.



1817

Paika Rebellion — Khurda, Odisha.

1825

Pagalpanthi — Bengal.

1828

Ahom Revolt — Assam.

1831

Kol Muting — Chota Nagpur Plateau.

1836

Moplah Rebellion — Malabar.

1855

Santhal Rebellion — Damin-i-Koh.

1857 — THE REVOLT OF 1857

1859

Indigo Revolt — Bengal.

1895–1900

Munda Rebellion (Ulgulan) — Chota Nagpur Plateau.



A CENTURY OF UNREST: some of these fed directly into 1857, others (like the Indigo Revolt & the Ulgulan) came AFTER it – but the root cause never changed: land, tax & control.



Exam Tip

Indigo Revolt (1859) leaders: **Digambar Biswas & Bishnu Biswas**. The exposing play: **Neel Darpan** by **Dinabandhu Mitra** — banned by the British for its impact!



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